

Water Damage

By MARTHA SOUTHGATE¹

Cullen Jones and Lia Neal were among the many swimmers to win medals for the United States in this year's Olympic Games. But their **inspiring(=exciting, breathtaking)** performances **obscureⁱ** a **disturbing(=worrying)** truth. Not only are they, as African-Americans, **anomaliesⁱⁱ** in the elite levels of their sport, but enormous numbers of African-Americans do not have even **rudimentaryⁱⁱⁱ** swimming skills, a lack that costs lives.

- i. Obscure means to hide, cover or conceal, 隐藏;
- ii. Anomaly means something different, abnormal, irregular, or a deviation from the common rule. 罕见, 少有;
- iii. Rudimentary has many synonyms, like basic, fundamental, elementary.

A 2010 study by the USA Swimming Foundation and the University of Memphis reported that nearly 70 percent of African-American children do not know how to swim. According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, African-American children between the ages of 5 and 14 are almost three times more likely to **drown** than white children.

Cullen Jones could have been one of them; his parents put him in swim class after he almost drowned at the age of 5.^{iv} Jones has become an **evangelist^v** for the importance of swimming lessons, working with Make a Splash, a water-safety **initiative^{vi}** focused on **minority** children. But it can be **tough(=hard)** even to **give** swimming lessons **away^{vii}**. Starting last fall, the Boys and Girls Clubs of Boston made swimming lessons **mandatory^{viii}** for their members, who are **predominantly(=mainly)** black and Hispanic. Though the lessons were free of charge, a number of parents had to be **talked into^{ix}** allowing their children to participate: they were **terrified** of letting them get in the water.

- iv. 该句的两个分句之间的逻辑呈“致使关系”, 英文里我们叫: cause and effect. 它不完全等同于汉语的“因果关系”, 即 Cause and effect 不完全等同于 Cause and result;
- v. Evangelist with the capital E(Evangelist) refers particularly to the writer of the Gospels, 大写的 Evangelist 是专有名词, 特指创作《圣经》四部福音书的人; 小写的 evangelist 是语义的泛化现象, 表示为某一事业宣传的人, an enthusiastic advocate, standard-supporter;
- vi. Initiative means a plan, a cause.
- vii. Give away means to give as a gift for 表示赠予.
- viii. Mandatory means required by a law or rule, obligatory, 强制的, 法律要求的;
- ix. Talk sb into doing something, “into”这个介词有被动语义, 表示说服, 诱导去做. E.g. Don't talk yourself into staying. 别勉强自己留下来。

This **bears out^x** the USA Swimming Foundation's finding, in its 2010 report, that “fear **trumped(=surpass, outstrip 超过)** financial **concerns** across all **respondent^{xi}** race groups in low-income families.”

- x. Bear out means to confirm. 证实;
- xi. Respondent here is an adj.; it means giving a response, 做出回应的;

Regardless of race, the poor lack access to pools and swimming lessons. Around 40 percent of white children and 60 percent of Hispanic children do not know how to swim — they, too, could benefit from free or **affordable** lessons. But why is the problem worse among African-Americans, many of whom, across all economic classes, lack confidence in the water? A large part of that **unease(=anxiety)** is a **legacy** of slavery and segregation.

It has been **documented(=registered 被记载)** that before slavery, many West Africans could and did swim. But a slave who could swim was a slave with another means of escape, so slave owners **went to great lengths to(=use various means to)** make it impossible to keep this skill alive.

Later, segregation **took its** ugly **toll^{xii}** at public beaches and pools. According to the historian Jeff Wiltse in an NPR interview, “whites set up, essentially, sentinel guards **at the entrance** to the pool, and when black swimmers tried to come in and **access(此处就表示利用, 使用)** them, they were beaten up, sometimes with clubs(警棍).” One white motel^{xiii} manager was caught on camera **pouring acid(倒酸水)** into a pool in which blacks were **staging^{xiv}** a “swim-in.”^{xv} **Institutionalized racism** was **shored up** by specious(=unreliable) scholarship^{xvi}, like a 1969 report titled “The Negro and Learning to Swim: The Buoyancy(浮力) Problem Related to Reported Biological Difference.”

xii. 这个词组在本学期 Unit 1 Text A 中学过, toll means cost, price 代价; take an **ugly** toll means take an **unpleasant** toll, 带来不让人愉悦的, 或者带来惨痛的代价。

xiii. Motel is a combination of “motor” and “hotel”, 字面意义是发动机旅馆, 实则指汽车旅馆。汽车旅馆简易, 一般位于美国城郊, 而非城内。

xiv. Stage 名词变动词, 上演;

xv. Swim-in refers specifically to the protest of the African-Americans fighting for the equal right of having access to water.

-in means protest; it is a noun. So swim-in means a swim protest. Protesters swim in a place in order to protest against discrimination.

Likewise, we have “sit-in”(静坐抗议). It refers to a situation where protesters stage a sitting protest against a place where they are not allowed to be sit or relaxed.

We have “study-in”(学习抗议). It refers to a situation where protesters stage a study protest against a place which denies their access to study materials or resources.

xvi. Institutionalised means established as a common belief, 司空见惯的, 已被普遍接受的, 根深蒂固的. Institutionalised racism means an established racism, 已被普遍接受的种族歧视; Shore up means to support with evidence.

So the sentence means that the deep racism was further supported by unreliable knowledge or research.

Sadly, the fear of water that was **instilled^{xvii}(灌入, 注入)** in African-Americans back then has become **self-perpetuating^{xviii}**. “Don’t you know blacks don’t swim?” Jones remembers being told by members of his family. It’s time to bury that **stereotype(a fixed thinking pattern, 固定的思维方式)** at sea. **As of(=From)** 2010, 15 European countries had made swimming a **compulsory(=mandatory)** part of their

education curriculums. **Ideally**, the United States would do the same. Not likely, I know, when even dry land physical education programs are being **slashed(to reduce, cut sharply)**. But we can and should do better.

xvii. 灌入知识, 或者不以理性或理解为前提的知识灌输, 除了 to instill students with...表达之外, 还有 to stuff / squeeze knowledge into...;

xviii. 我们怎么理解这里的 self-perpetuating? Perpetuate means to cause to last eternally. So self-perpetuate means to cause oneself to continually follow that fixed thinking pattern, 让自己不停地处于类似的固定模式的思考之中, 永无止境。

This country **is blessed with**^{xix} a network of community centers like the Y.M.C.A. and the Boys and Girls Clubs that have swimming programs, instructors and pools in place. These centers could take Boston's example and make swimming lessons mandatory, which would benefit their clientele(=a body of customers, 客户群), regardless of its racial **makeup**^{xx}. Public schools (and particularly charter schools, many of which have extended their school years into summer's heat) could **devote** part of each summer to **shuttling**^{xxi} their students to swim programs.

xix. Be blessed with here means to be endowed with, to be favoured with, 表示有幸拥有, 被赋予;

xx. Regardless of its racial makeup means without taking into consideration of the way these customers are composed.撇开其种族构成, 或与其种族构成无关;

xxi. Shuttle means a vehicle that goes back and forth regularly, 其实就是公交车; 此处名词作动词, to shuttle means to transport.

Another model is the public-private partnership, like Horizons National, an academic summer program that **partners** low-income schools **with**^{xxii} independent schools and colleges that have access to swimming pools. Here's a quote (posted on the program's Web site) from one **participant**: "When I started Horizons I was so afraid of the water that I would not even go in the **shallow** end. Learning how to swim and overcoming that fear helped me realize that I could do anything." Who said this? Algernon Kelley, who now has a Ph.D. in chemistry and lectured at Xavier University of Louisiana.

xxii. To partner A with B 是典型的名词动用现象。上学期我们给了类似的例子, 如 I **room** with him. 我和他睡一间房;

Spoon me some soup. 给我舀一勺汤;

He **eyed** her from her silver hair to the tips of her toes 他从头到脚扫了她一眼;

George **bicycled** home;

Please **word** your gratitude for her support.(Word means to express.)

The best way to **eliminate(to remove, get rid of, rule out 清除)** the culture of anxiety around swimming is to create thousands of little African-American swimmers who are not afraid. I was one of those swimmers — never elite but always **joyous(=happy)**. My parents **packed** me and my siblings **off to**^{xxiii} the pool at our local community center as soon as we were old enough, and I became the kind of kid who would get out of the water only when my lips were **blue**^{xxiv}. How wonderful if more children could feel the joy and confidence I feel when I'm swimming — and be safer around the water, too.

xxiii. Pack sb off to a place simply means to send sb to a certain location.

xxiv. When one's lips go blue, he/she may suffer from a lack of oxygen. So here the author means he has already overcome the fear of water, and revealed even a strong love for staying beneath the water as long as he could bear.

The United States faces **immense** problems of all kinds, many of which are more **pressing**(=**critical, urgent, demanding immediate attention**) than teaching children to swim. But for a mother who stands screaming on the shore as her child goes under for the last time, not knowing how to swim is the biggest problem there is.^{xxiv}

xxv. 这个句子的是主系表结构。主语——Not knowing how to swim, 系动词——is, 表语——the biggest problem. 所以, the biggest problem there is 只是一个短语结构, 属于非正式用语。正式的书面写作里我们会说: a severe problem that exists.